Characters & relationships

Compare the couple

1 Macbeth's transformation

"Brave Macbeth" (1.2) → secret desire → hesitation → murder → independent tyranny.

"Fruitless crown" (3.1): power without secure inheritance. "Walking shadow" (5.5): achievement feels empty.

Pity for wasted potential can coexist with condemnation.

2 Lady Macbeth's change

"Unsex me here" (1.5): she tries to suppress compassion. Challenges manhood; controls the plan.

"A little water" (2.2) minimises guilt; sleepwalking and "damned spot" (5.1) expose its persistence.

Her requests for cruelty can reveal vulnerability, not effortless evil.

Study alternatives

3 Marriage: power shifts

Shared plan → Macbeth alone

Her control → Her isolation

Act 1: "partner of greatness"; shared ambition. Act 2: she returns daggers and covers panic.

Act 3: he plans Banquo's death without her; she tries to protect his image at the banquet.

Act 5: emotional isolation. He is not controlled by her throughout.

4 Banquo & Macduff

Banquo is a foil: shares curiosity about prophecy but warns of deception; Fleance's escape keeps Macbeth insecure.

Macduff resists tyranny and grieves: "I must also feel it as a man" (4.3).

His duty to Scotland conflicts painfully with family safety.

Track the victims

5 Duncan & Malcolm

Duncan rewards service but misjudges loyalty. His trust makes Macbeth's betrayal more disturbing.

Malcolm tests Macduff before trusting him; responsible kingship contrasts with self-protection.

Ending restores political order, without undoing suffering.

6 Witches & innocents

Witches offer tempting predictions and double meanings; they never tell Macbeth to kill Duncan.

Lady Macduff and her son make the cost of tyranny visible through domestic dialogue and stage violence.

Fleance escapes; the play does not show his future kingship.